MA ENGLISH • SEMESTER 1

Block 2 — Unit 2: Poetry - Sonnets 18 and 55

SHAKESPEARE STUDIES • M21EG02DC

Expanded exam notes | Simple teaching + developed argument

Based on the supplied SGOU self-learning material. Use the assigned primary texts for exact quotations and full scene or passage analysis.

The chapter in one sentence

Sonnets 18 and 55 imagine poetry preserving a beloved person against change, destruction, and forgetting.

Start with a picture

A flower fades. A statue can break. A poem can be read again by someone who never met the person it describes. Shakespeare builds arguments about memory from this contrast.

1. Sonnet 18: begin with the comparison

The speaker asks whether to compare the beloved to a summer’s day. The poem then shows why summer is an imperfect measure: rough winds disturb it, heat can be excessive, cloud can hide brightness, and its season is short.

The opening is not a simple statement that nature is perfect. It prepares an argument that natural beauty changes and therefore cannot guarantee permanence.

Move through the poem

- **Lines 1–4:** the proposed comparison is tested against the instability of summer.
- **Lines 5–8:** broader natural decline is associated with chance and changing conditions.
- **Lines 9–12:** the turn asserts that the beloved’s “eternal summer” will endure in verse.
- **Lines 13–14:** continued human reading is made the condition of the poem’s life and its gift of life.

Explain “immortality” carefully

The poem does not claim that a physical body becomes biologically immortal. It imagines a person’s beauty and presence preserved through language and readership. The final confidence also depends on readers continuing to encounter the poem.

2. Sonnet 55: begin with monuments

The speaker compares verse with marble and gilded monuments. Time and warfare can destroy material objects, but the poem claims a different durability for the memory it carries.

Move through the poem

The opening challenges the prestige of monumental objects. War, conflict, and destruction intensify the threat. The later movement imagines the beloved’s praise reaching future generations, and the ending places life within the poem and the eyes of lovers who read it.

The poem uses the vocabulary of public commemoration to make an intimate claim. What looks fragile—a few lines of writing—is presented as more enduring than expensive stone.

3. Compare their imagery

Sonnet 18	Sonnet 55
Summer, wind, heat, shade	Marble, monuments, war, destruction
Change in the natural world	Destruction in the material and historical world
The beloved’s summer survives in verse	The beloved’s memory survives monuments
Reading renews poetic life	Future readers carry remembrance

The poems share a claim about art, but they reach it through different kinds of threatened beauty and memory.

4. Form supports thought

Both follow fourteen-line English-sonnet design with rhyme ABAB CDCD EFEF GG and predominantly iambic pentameter. Three quatrains develop the argument, while the couplet gives a concentrated ending. Metre is a framework, not a requirement to speak every line mechanically.

The **volta** is a turn in the argument. In Sonnet 18, the emphatic change at line 9 is especially important. In any sonnet, examine the actual thought rather than assuming every turn must occur in the same place.

Quick check

1. Why is summer an imperfect comparison? **It is changeable and brief.**
2. What threatens monuments in Sonnet 55? **Time, neglect, and destructive conflict.**
3. What keeps poetic memory alive? **The continued life of the poem through readers.**

Build an exam answer

1. State the shared concern with time and memory.
2. Analyse summer’s imperfection in Sonnet 18.
3. Explain the turn and reader-dependent conclusion.
4. Contrast monuments and verse in Sonnet 55.
5. Evaluate the nature of the promised immortality.

Common mistake to avoid

Do not say Sonnet 18 merely compares someone to pleasant weather. Distinguish physical survival from survival in poetic memory.

Developed exam discussion

Practice question

Compare how Sonnets 18 and 55 use threatened objects to claim poetic permanence.

Explain the argument in fuller paragraphs

Both poems present verse as a medium capable of resisting the destructive effects of time. Their confidence emerges through comparison rather than abstract assertion alone. Sonnet 18 tests natural beauty and finds it unstable, while Sonnet 55 challenges the apparent permanence of public monuments. Each poem makes the vulnerability of one medium the basis for elevating another.

Sonnet 18 first weakens the conventional praise of a summer’s day. Winds, heat, cloud, and seasonal brevity make the comparison inadequate. The argument then expands from summer to the decline of beautiful things generally. At the turn, “eternal summer” transfers the beloved’s beauty into a poetic form that claims to escape those conditions. The couplet makes the poem’s continued existence central to the preservation it promises.

Sonnet 55 works through a more public language of commemoration. Marble and gilding suggest wealth and official prestige, yet both remain exposed to historical violence. The poem contrasts such destruction with the movement of praise across generations. Its argument is therefore also about value: expensive material display is not necessarily the most durable way to secure remembrance.

The poems should not be treated as literal scientific claims about immortality. Their permanence depends on cultural transmission and acts of reading. This dependence can qualify, without cancelling, the speaker’s confidence. A mature answer explains both the assertion and its conditions, showing how formal repetition, contrast, and the final couplet persuade readers to participate in the preservation being imagined.

How to use this discussion

Adapt the argument to the exact wording and marks of your question. Use one point per paragraph and support it with a scene, line, image, or formal detail. Verify exact quotations in the assigned text. The discussion is explanatory paraphrase, not a quotation or a guaranteed model answer.

Textbook assignment checklist

These are the unit’s assignment prompts for revision. They are not predictions or a set of fully written assignment submissions.

1. Analyse how the volta in Sonnet 18 transforms the poem’s focus from natural imperfection to poetic immortality.

2. Discuss the ways in which Sonnet 55 contrasts physical monuments with the lasting power of verse.
3. Compare the use of natural imagery in Sonnet 18 with monumental imagery in Sonnet 55 to explore their shared theme of immortality.
4. Examine Shakespeare’s use of iambic pentameter and rhyme scheme in reinforcing the themes of time and permanence.
5. Reflect on the personal and universal dimensions of love as portrayed in these two sonnets